Using Polls to Identify the Roosevelt Coalition

by

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The voter coalition Franklin Roosevelt fashioned during the Great Depression is still a prominent force in politics today. More than four decades after his death, social scientists still debate its existence and influence on election outcomes. Many Presidential candidates continue to pay homage to Roosevelt's role in their own careers, drawing on his immense stature to further their own ambitions, even avowed conservatives such as Ronald Reagan.[1]

Interestingly, the historical literature contains little description or analysis of the Roosevelt coalition in its heyday during the 1930s and early 1940s. Most New Deal election studies focus mainly on how candidates maneuvered their way through "smoke-filled rooms," the nominating conventions, and the campaigns, and ignore the people who elected them. Survey data from those years, which permits direct analysis of these voters, is largely ignored because many researchers consider pre-1950s polls flawed by inadequate sampling techniques. Thus, polls by commercial agencies such as Gallup, Roper and Crossley, or by academic agencies such as the National Opinion Research Center are virtually untouched. Aside from a few important community

[1] Leuchtenburg, W.E., In the Shadow of FDR: From Harry Truman to Ronald Reagan, (Ithaca, Cornell Press, 1983).

and state studies, much of what we know about Roosevelt voters comes from eyewitness accounts and analysis of election returns from large geographic areas.[2] This paper is meant to encourage use of these polls and present some conclusions about the Roosevelt coalition during its years of dominance between 1936 and 1944.

The study of early polling techniques is an important subject, but well beyond the scope of this paper. These polls, of course, grossly undersampled southerners, women, nonwhites and the undereducated. Furthermore, they contain few questions about the attitudes and demographics of the people they polled. Despite their limitations, polls from these years are quite useable and and normally accurate.[3]

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[2] Lubell, Samuel: The Future of American Politics. Garden City, N.Y., Doubleday, 1952; Jeffries, John: Testing the Roosevelt Coalition: Connecticut Society and Politics in the Era of World War II. Knoxville, University of Tennessee Press, 1979 is an exemplary state study; the best community study is the pioneering study by Lazarsfeld, Paul, et al.: The People's Choice: How the Voter Makes Up His Mind In A Presidential Campaign. New York, Duell, Sloan and Pearce, 1944; Allswang, John: The New Deal and American Politics. New York, Wiley, 1978 is an excellent political science study which combines election returns with census data, but stops in 1938. Studies which use national survey data are Key, V. O., Jr.: The Responsible Electorate: Rationality in Presidential Voting, 1936-1960. Cambridge, Harvard University Press, 1966; and Ladd, Everett Carll, Jr., and Hadley, Charles D.: Transformations of the American Party System: Political Coalitions from the New Deal to the 1970s. New York, Norton, 1975. Neither study, however, explores very deeply the interactions of variables.

[3] Further information is available in Glenn, Norval: "Trend Studies With Available Survey Data: Opportunites and Pitfalls." In Survey Data For Trend Analysis: An Index to Repeated Questions in U.S. National Surveys, pp. I-6-I-50. Williamstown, Roper Center, 1975; Jensen, Richard J.: "Public Opinion Polls; Early Problems of

The focus of this paper is therefore on the voters themselves, not on the quality of the polls to which they responded.

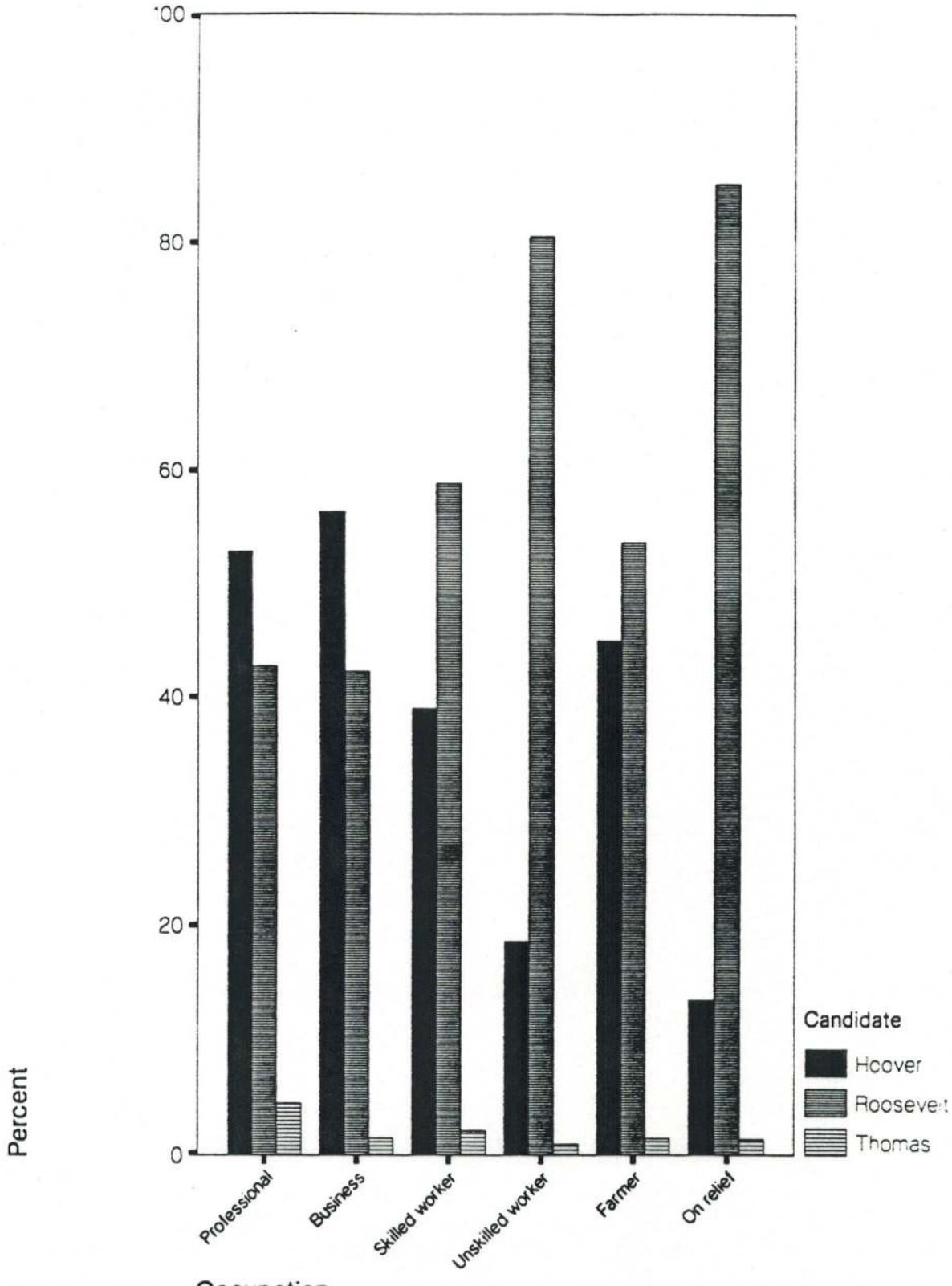
The 1932 election probably had little effect on the eventual composition of the Roosevelt coalition. People from nearly every walk of life were dissatisfied with Hoover as president and voted Democratic that year. For example, based on their 1936 jobs, the only groups who favored Hoover were professionals and businessman; farmers, skilled workers, unskilled workers and reliefers strongly supported Roosevelt (Figure 1).

Unfortunately, we cannot examine 1932 voting directly; the first public opinion polls as we know them were taken in 1936. The only survey information we have on 1932 voters are questions in 1936 polls which asked respondents to remember how they voted four years earlier. However, recall questions are useful for measuring the level of party switching between elections. For example, Social Security was a key New Deal program, and ex-Roosevelt voters who opposed the plan clearly switched more often to Landon than those who favored it (Figure 2). Similarly, 1932 Hoover voters who supported Social Security were more likely to vote Democratic than those who did not (Figure 3).

Method and Philosophy." Paper presented at the Oxford Conference on the History and Theory of the Social Sciences, July 28, 1977; and Mott, James: The Fate of an Alliance: The Roosevelt Coalition, 1932-1952. Ph.D. dissertation, University of Illinois at Chicago, 1988.

Figure 1
1932 Presidential Voting by Occupation

(Non-Southern Voters Only)

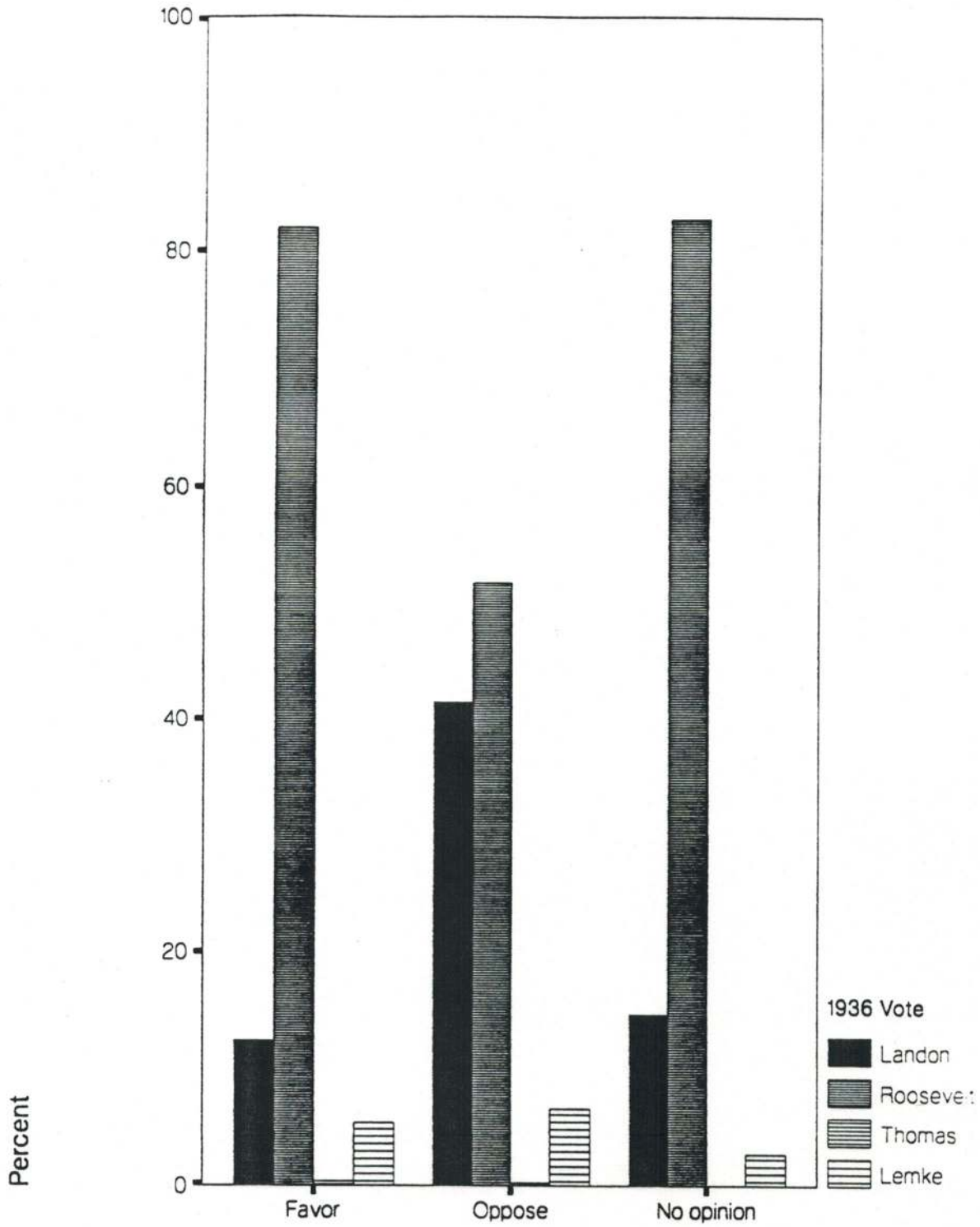


Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

Figure 2

The 1936 vote by position on Social Security

(1932 Non-Southern Roosevelt Voters Only)



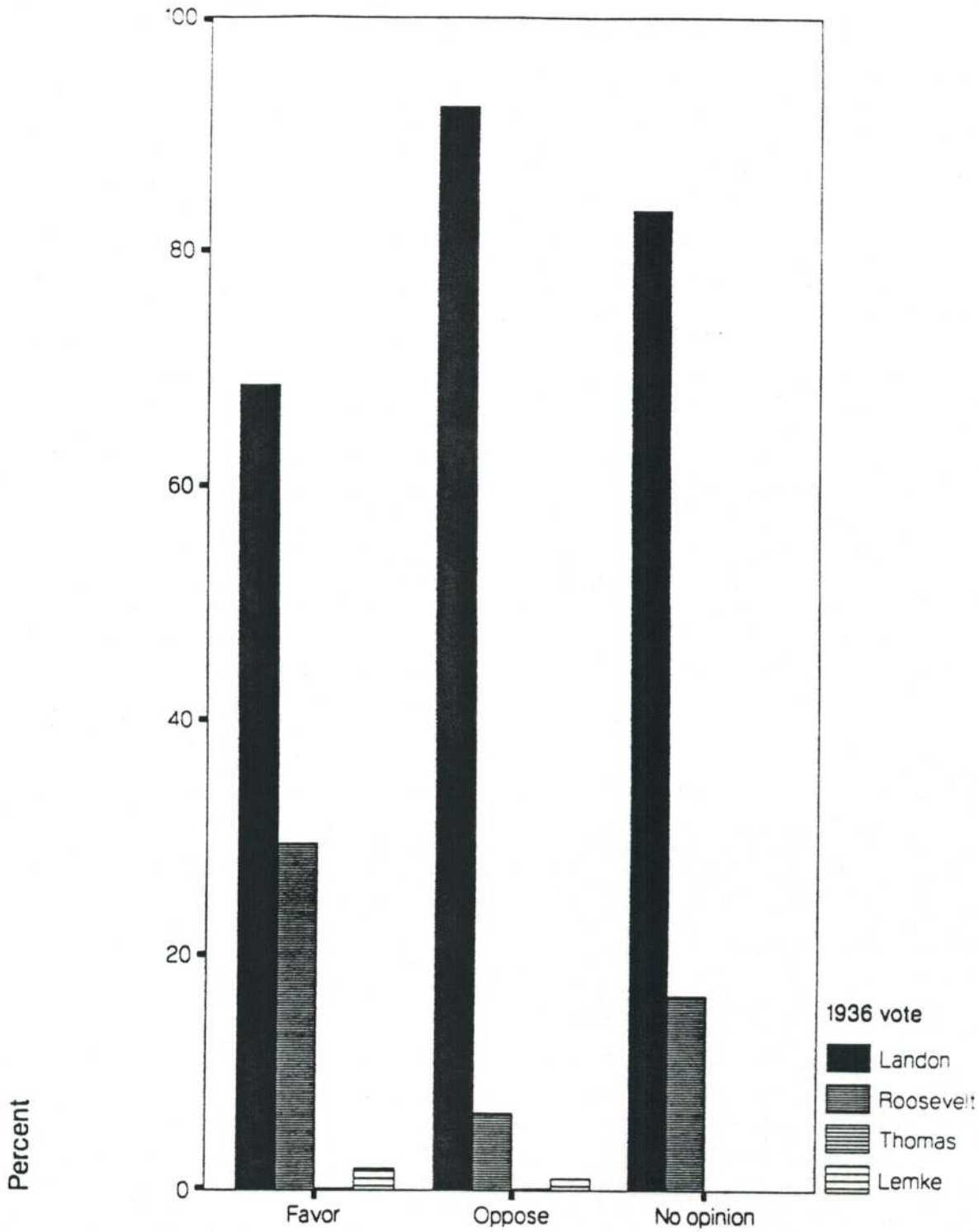
Position on Social Security

Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

Figure 3

The 1936 vote by position on Social Security

(1932 Non-Southern Hoover Voters Only)



Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

Switching among 1932 Roosevelt voters varied dramatically according to class. For example, 56.1% of upper-class voters who opposed Social Security changed to Landon in 1936, and 56.9% of middle-class voters switched, but only 21.5% and 18.5% of lower-class and on-relief opponents shifted to the Republicans. Poorer voters evidently favored Roosevelt whether they agreed with his policies or not; the rich only voted for him if they supported his policies. In contrast, upper, middle and lower-class Hoover voters were equally likely to switch because of the Social Security issue, which indicates that class did not affect switching among 1932 Hoover voters; upper-class voters who favored the plan were just as likely to switch to Roosevelt as middle-class and lower-class voters. Ex-Hoover voters on relief were clearly in a class alone; lured by relief, they were likely to switch whether they liked Social Security or not (Table I).

The fact that so many of Roosevelt's 1932 lower-class and on-relief voters who opposed Social Security remained loyal despite their opposition to a central New Deal issue suggests that issues did not play a dominant role in how they voted. Though the data are sketchy, this becomes clearer through multivariate analysis. In Table II, questions on Social Security, and also some proposed farm aid legislation are combined into a scaled variable called New Dealism, which ranges from a top extreme of +2 to a low

TABLE I

PROBABILITY OF SWITCHING OF 1932 VOTERS BY OPINION OF SOCIAL SECURITY AND ECONOMIC LEVEL, NON-SOUTH

	1932 FDR			1932 Hoover		
	FDR-FDR	FDR-Landon	N	Hoover-Landon	Hoover-FDR	N
Social Security						
Favor						
Economic level						
Above average	86.4%	13.6%	330	71.9%	28.1%	210
Average	84.2	15.8	266	66.1	33.9	192
Below average	87.2	12.8	406	72.2	27.8	144
On relief	91.3	8.7	184	50.0	50.0	22
Against						
Economic level						
Above average	43.9%	56.1%	132	94.5%	5.5%	236
Average	43.1	56.9	102	95.1	4.9	243
Below average	78.5	21.5	79	89.2	10.8	83
On relief	81.5	18.5	27	54.5	45.5	11

Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936). Table entries are the proportion of 1932 voters who switched to another party.

extreme of -2. If a respondent liked both programs, they received a score of +2; if they opposed both plans, they were assigned a -2. Values in between were given to respondents who favored one program but not the other, or favored one plan but had no opinion on the other program, etc.

Roosevelt's low-income supporters were clearly less influenced by these issues than his middle and upper income supporters. Correlations between New Dealism and the 1936 vote for respondents with average and above average incomes

(0.43 and 0.35) were substantially greater than for respondents with below average incomes (0.21). This was because low-income voters were more likely than well-to-do voters to resupport Roosevelt, even if they disagreed with his policies (Figure 4). Most other factors were identical across classes, which means that the same social and community factors affected all ex-Roosevelt voters alike.

TABLE II

CORRELATES OF THE 1936 VOTE BY INCOME LEVEL, 1932 ROOSEVELT VOTERS ONLY

		Income Level		
	All	Lower	Middle	Upper
New Dealism	.30	.21	.43	.35
Occupation	.05	.04	.08	.05
Age	.07	.08	.08	.09
Size of place	.01	.02	.05	.04
Sex	.03	.02	.01	.05

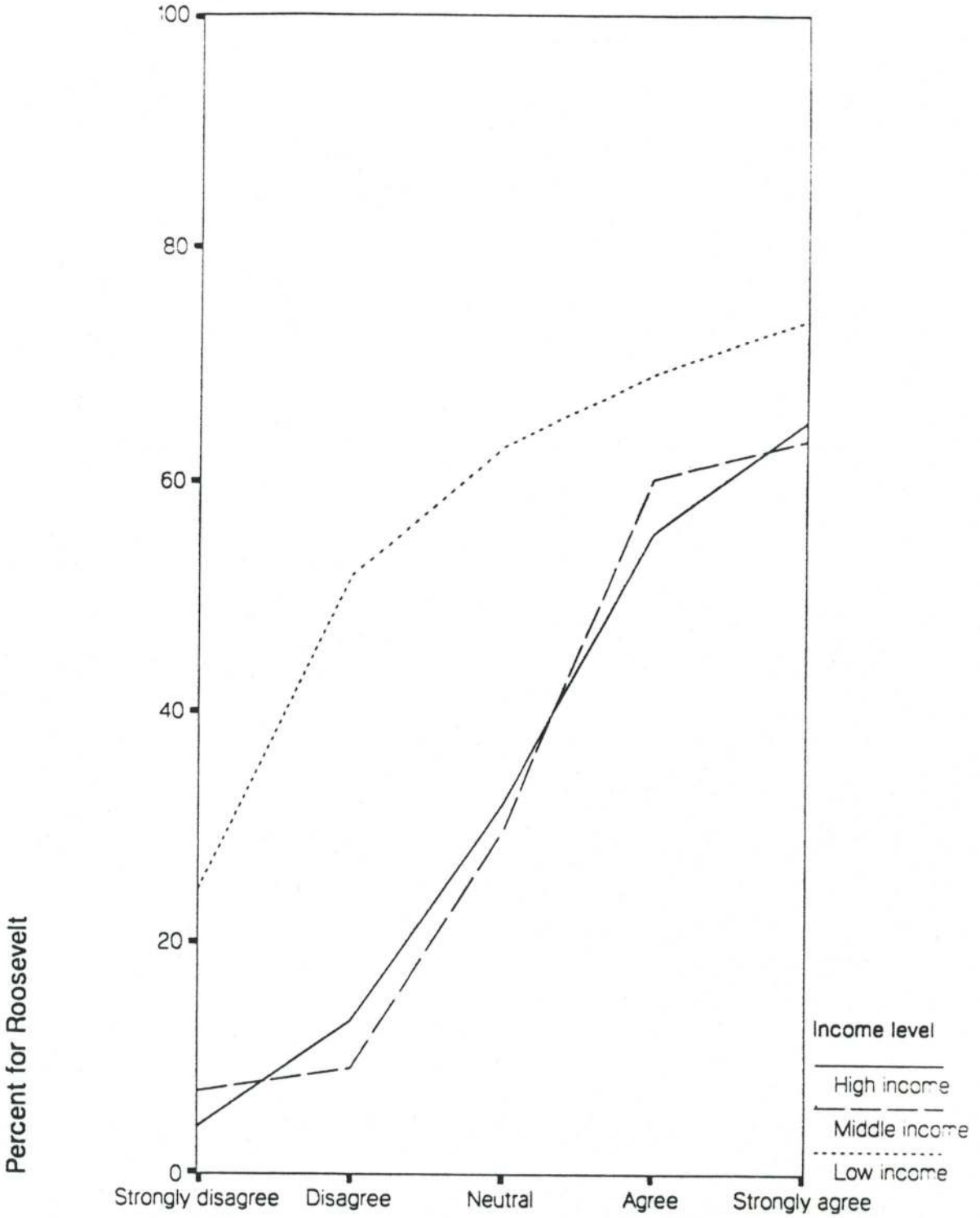
Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936). There were 1051 lower, 566 middle and 855 upper income voters. Entries are eta coefficients with a Roosevelt vote = 100, a Republican vote = 0, and other-novote = 50.

For Roosevelt, the switching which did occur paid tremendous dividends because it left him with a coalition firmly behind his policies. Table III shows that most Roosevelt voters from all classes liked the New Deal to that point. Nearly 80% of them supported both Social Security and farm loan legislation. Only a few supported one

Figure 4

Percent for Roosevelt by Income Level by New Deal position

(1932 Non-Southern Roosevelt Voters Only)



Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

TABLE III

1936 PRESIDENTIAL VOTING BY SOCIAL SECURITY & FARM LOANS BY INCOME LEVEL, NON-SOUTH

	Programs supported				
	Neither Program	Social Security Only	Farm Loans Only	Both Programs	N
1936 Roosevelt voters					
Income level					
High income	1.1%	4.5%	16.3%	78.1%	443
Middle income	2.5	6.0	14.0	77.5	365
Low income	2.3	9.8	12.7	75.2	480
On relief	.9	9.4	13.2	76.4	212
1936 Landon voters					
Income level					
High income	23.2	8.3	35.2	33.3	492
Middle income	27.8	7.9	34.0	30.9	424
Low income	13.4	10.1	22.1	54.4	217
On relief	17.9	10.3	20.5	51.3	39

Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

program, but not the other, and virtually no Roosevelt voters opposed both programs. A class-based tension, however, existed among Landon voters on the New Deal. The same table shows that low-income Republicans were much more supportive or Social Security and farm loans than higher-income Republicans. Over half favored both programs, but less than 40% of higher-income voters supported both. It is interesting, however, that most of Landon's supporters approved of loans to tenant farmers, indicating that Republicans from all classes shared equal concern for the plight of tenant farmers, and also that old age insurance was more offensive to Landon voters than assisting farmers.

Reaction to the Social Security issue implies that Republican leadership was out of touch with its constituency. It also implies that more future defections could be expected unless the GOP accommodated the liberal attitudes of the poor. In a 1938 Gallup poll, more than half of all Republicans said they thought the party should be more liberal than it was in 1936. The highest vote for change came from Republicans in the cities, 60% of whom said the party should become more liberal. Small town Republicans also prefered a more liberal party by a majority of 55%. On the other hand, Republican farmers were much less in favor of liberalizing the party. A slight majority (53%) thought it should either be more conservative or about the same as in 1936, while 47% wanted it to be more liberal.[4]

The reason party members wanted to liberalize the party was to enhance the Republican party's chances for victory in 1940. Asked whether the Republican party had a better or worse chance of winning in 1940 if it nominated a liberal candidate and adopted a liberal platform, 77% of Republicans responded that it would have a better chance, and only 14% said it would have a worse chance.[5] The growing liberal

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[4] American Institute for Public Opinion (AIPO) survey no. 135, (October, 1938). In Gallup, George, ed.: The Gallup Poll: Public Opinion 1935-1971, vol 1, (New York, 1972). p. 122.

[5] "American Institute of Public Opinion--Surveys, 1938-1939." In The Public Opinion Quarterly, (October, 1939), p. 583.

stance of rank-and-file Republicans is made even clearer in their choices for the GOP presidential candidate in 1940, which showed the more liberal Thomas Dewey well ahead of his conservative opponents, such as Robert Taft, Alf Landon and Herbert Hoover (Table IV).

TABLE IV

REPUBLICAN 1940 PRESIDENTIAL PREFERENCE

Candidate	Nov. '38	Feb. '39	Mar. '39	May '39	Aug. '39
Dewey	33%	27%	50%	54%	45%
Vandenberg	18	21	15	13	25
Taft	18	16	13	15	14
Hoover	6	--	5	4	6
Landon	6	7	4	--	3
Borah	--	4	--	3	--
Others	19	25	13	11	7

Source: Data compiled from various Gallup Polls by The Public Quarterly, October, 1939, p. 583.

After years of total war against the New Deal, many Republicans accepted some of Roosevelt's innovations, at least grudgingly. In 1936, for example, the Republican platform called the Social Security Act "unworkable." By 1939, however, GOP leaders in the House of Representatives supported amendments that extended benefits to dependents and survivors of insured workers. In its 1944 platform, the Dewey led party actually endorsed old-age insurance for the first time, by calling for an "extension of the old-age

insurance and unemployment insurance systems to all employees not already covered." This did not mean partisan conflict on Social Security had ended. Republicans always thought they could manage the program better than could the Democrats. However, after 1940, the GOP no longer fought the Democrats over the principle of Social Security and often joined them in supporting increased payments and coverage. In fact, by 1952, most Republicans were saying they favored New Deal-Fair Deal programs in general, the major exception being farm support programs (Table V).

TABLE V

REPUBLICAN ATTITUDES IN RETROSPECT ON KEY NEW DEAL PROGRAMS IN 1952

	Position			
Program	Good thing	50-50	No opinion	Mistake
Social Security	86%	9%	1%	4%
Tennessee Valley Authority	65	11	14	10
Recognition of labor unions	50	11	20	19
Farm Price Supports	40	15	11	34

Source: RCOM No. 62, October, 1952, N = 1203.

According to conventional wisdom, several factors influenced voting during the Roosevelt years--income level, union membership, community size, religion, ethnicity. Most researchers agree that Roosevelt voters tended to be lower class, union members, big-city residents and non-

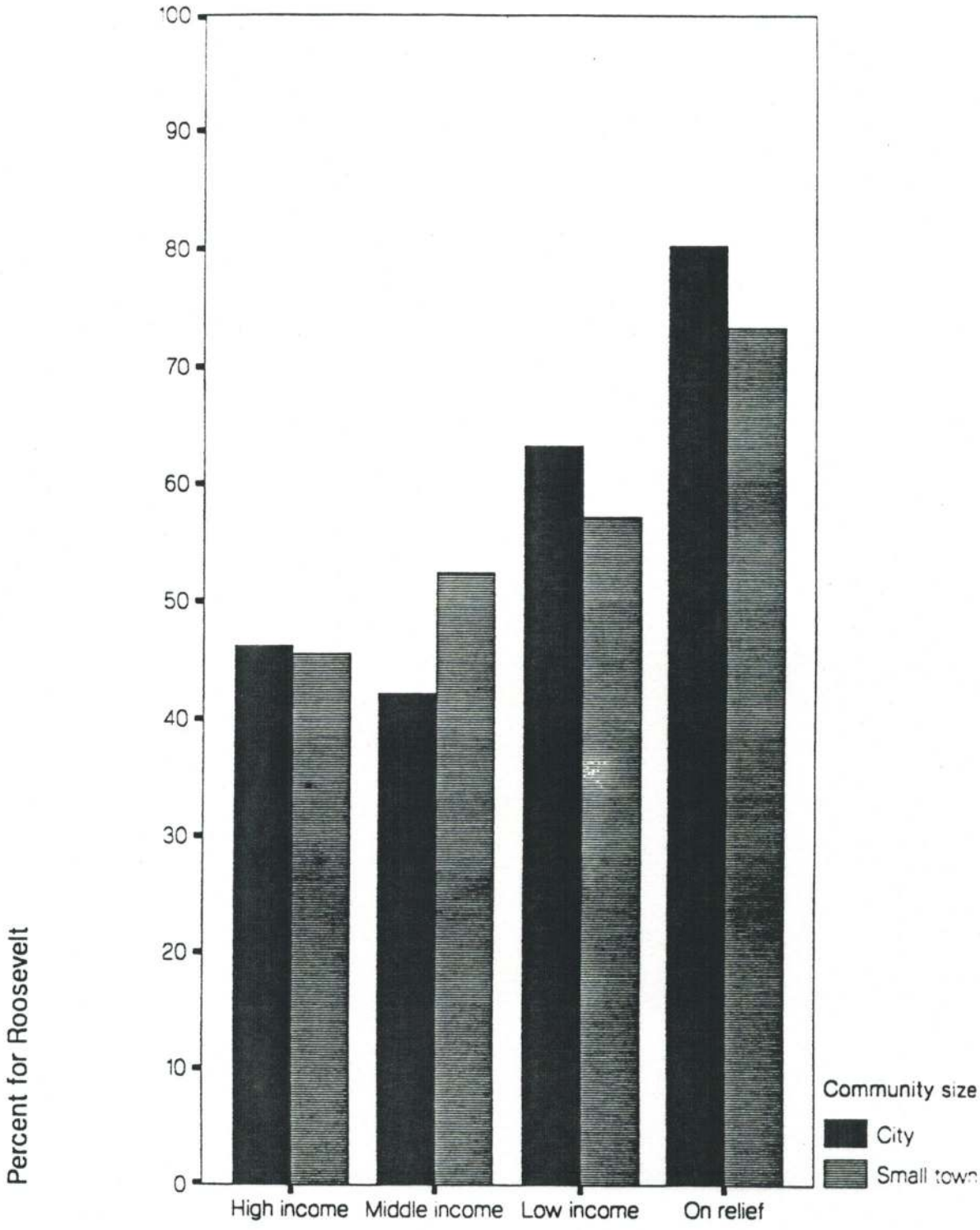
Protestants, and Republican voters were typically upper class, nonunion members, rural residents and Protestants. While 1936 polls do not have enough information to test all these assumptions, they do confirm the importance of income level on voting (Table VI). Multivariate analysis shows that the correlation between income level on the vote drops only slightly (from .26 to .22) after controlling for occupation, age, community size and sex. Most other factors that appeared important weakened considerably once controls were included. For example, the eta coefficient for occupation drops from .19 to .08, and for community size, from .10 to .04. What this means is that voters within a given profession tended to vote alike as long as their income levels were the same. For example, rich professionals voted like rich businessmen, and rich workers. It also means that wealthy city residents voted like their counterparts in small towns and on farms. Figure 5 cuts through the statistics to show how unimportant community size actually was when economic level is controlled for.

Fortunately, later polls contain abundant demographic information on voters. One poll in particular, the 1944 National Opinion Research Center poll, also asked respondents how they voted in three separate Presidential elections--1936, 1940 and 1944. The poll was conducted in two waves; the same respondents were interviewed both before and after the 1944 election, although some respondents were

Figure 5

1936 Presidential Voting by Income Level by Community Size

(Non-Southern Voters Only)



Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

TABLE VI

THE 1936 VOTE BY INCOME LEVEL, OCCUPATION, AGE, COMMUNITY SIZE AND SEX, NON-SOUTH ONLY

		Observed deviation above or below average	Eta	Adjusted deviation above or below average	Beta
Overall mean	N	55.2		55.2	
Income level			.26		.22
High income	1208	-8.5		-6.3	
Middle income	1033	-10.3		-9.2	
Low income	1012	10.1		8.0	
On relief	391	27.1		23.0	
Occupation			.19		.08
Professional	283	-9.6		-5.0	
Businessman	268	-18.6		-12.4	
Skilled worker	1952	1.1		1.7	
Unskilled worker	374	21.3		3.3	
Farmer	54	-18.1		-2.4	
Other, none	713	-1.9		.4	
Age group			.15		.12
21-24	60	-1.8		4.2	
25-34	868	9.5		7.4	
35-44	962	.5		.2	
45-54	1013	.5		-.1	
55 & older	741	-12.4		-9.2	
Community size			.10		.04
Large city	2670	2.7		1.0	
Small town	327	-12.2		-6.2	
Farm	647	-5.0		-1.0	
Sex			.01		.03
Male	2891	.2		.7	
Female	753	-.7		-2.6	

Source: AIPO no. 53 (October, 1936)

Entries are deviations above or below the overall mean.
A Roosevelt vote=100; a Republican vote=0; and other-novote=50.

unavailable for the second wave. This poll offers a unique opportunity to analyze the same voters over three elections, although it must be remembered that their social and economic characteristics might have changed after 1936. For example, almost no one was on relief in 1944, but millions were in 1936. We cannot identify those millions. It also offers the opportunity of examining variables that were not in the Gallup 1936 election poll namely religion, ethnicity and union membership.

Table VII follows the 1936 electorate through the 1940 and 1944 elections, and shows substantial Democrat-to-Republican shifting, but little movement the other way. Both in 1940 and 1944, 77% resupported Roosevelt, but an even higher percentage continued voting Republican. Also, it should be noted that Roosevelt had trouble hanging on to switchers; most Roosevelt voters who switched to Willkie in 1940 kept voting Republican in 1944, but most Landon voters who changed to Roosevelt shifted back to Dewey.

Roosevelt's coalition remained stable in the south, where he routinely won 80% of the vote. Outside the south, however, his demographic base changed considerably. A comparison of correlation coefficients between the vote and various social and community characteristics reveals substantial class realignment between 1936 and 1940, as the rich swung to the Republicans, forcing Roosevelt to rely on the lower classes for votes. In addition, he increasingly

TABLE VII

WHO ROOSEVELT AND LANDON SUPPORTERS VOTED FOR IN 1940 AND 1944

1936 Roosevelt Voters N=1134				1936 Landon Voters N=620			
1940 Election				1940 Election			
Roosevelt 77.1% N=863		Willkie 15.8% N=177		Roosevelt 6.5% N=40		Willkie 88.0% N=542	
1944 Election				1944 Election			
Roosevelt 77.0% N=539	Dewey 10.3% N=72	Roosevelt 23.6% N=34	Dewey 66.0% N=95	Roosevelt 40.6% N=13	Dewey 53.1% N=17	Roosevelt 3.9% N=17	Dewey 91.3% N=398

Source: NORC nos. 229/230 (October-November, 1944). Percentages do not total 100% because of non-voters, and persons who switched to third-parties.

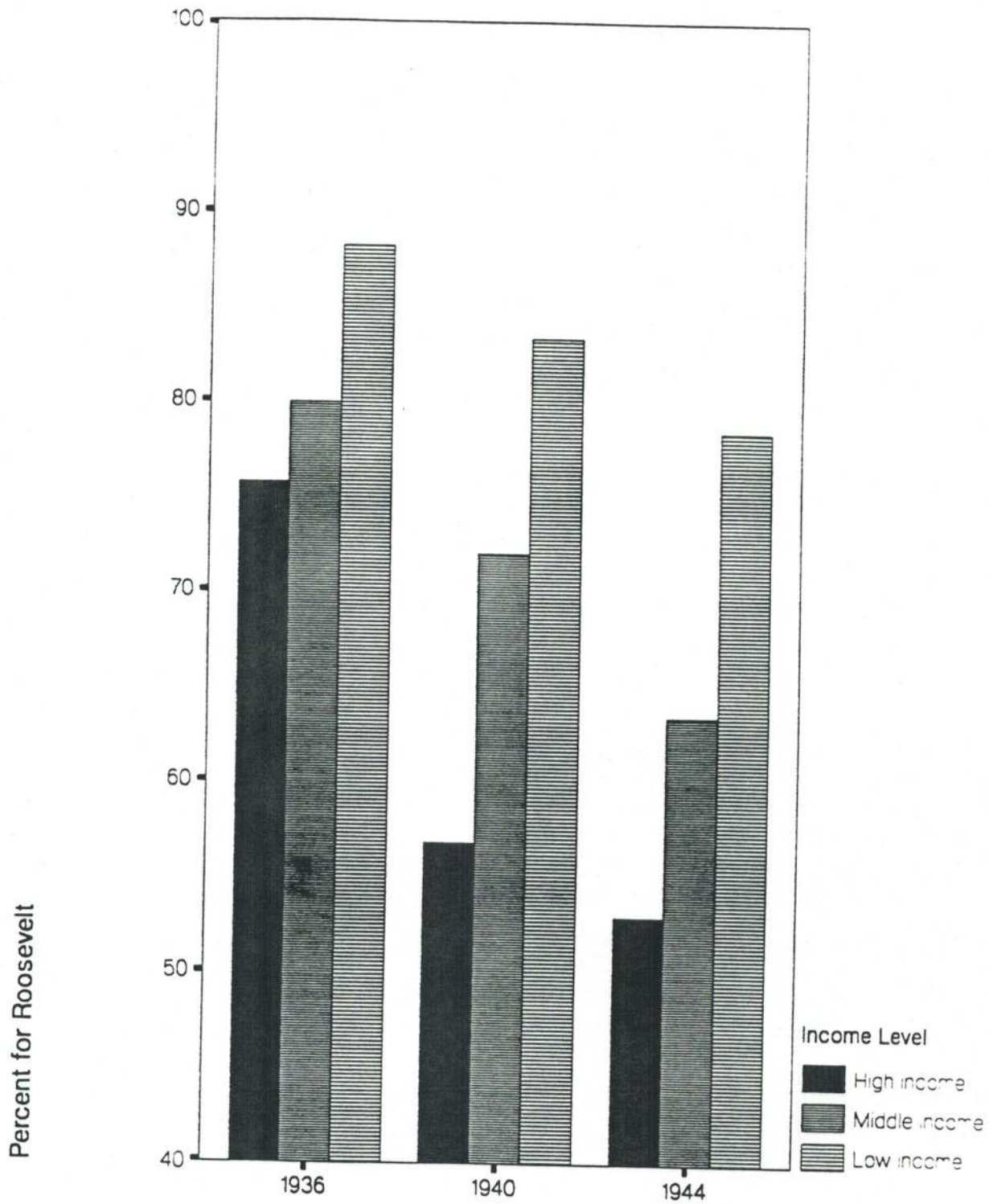
had to rely on large cities and on union members. Table VIII shows that income level, membership in a union and also community size had an increasingly greater effect on the vote after 1936.

These factors affected Democrats and Republicans alike. For example, Catholics provided nearly 25% of Roosevelt's 1936 vote, but in 1940, large numbers of rich Catholics voted for Willkie. In contrast, few lower and middle income Catholics switched (Figure 6). Note that 1936 differences were small (the difference between extremes was only 12.4 points), but by 1940, it widened considerably (to a

Figure 6

Catholic Support for Roosevelt by Income Level, 1936-1944

(Non-Southern Voters Only)



Source: NORC nos. 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

TABLE VIII

CORRELATES OF THE VOTE, 1936-1944, NON-SOUTH

	Election Year		
	1936	1940	1944
Demographic			
Religion	.25	.26	.28
Ethnic origin	.18	.18	.19
Income level	.16	.21	.22
Union membership	.14	.17	.19
Community size	.13	.14	.18

Entries are eta coefficients. This statistic measures the effect of each variable on the vote without controlling for other variables in the equation. A Roosevelt vote=100; a Republican vote=0; and other-novote=50.

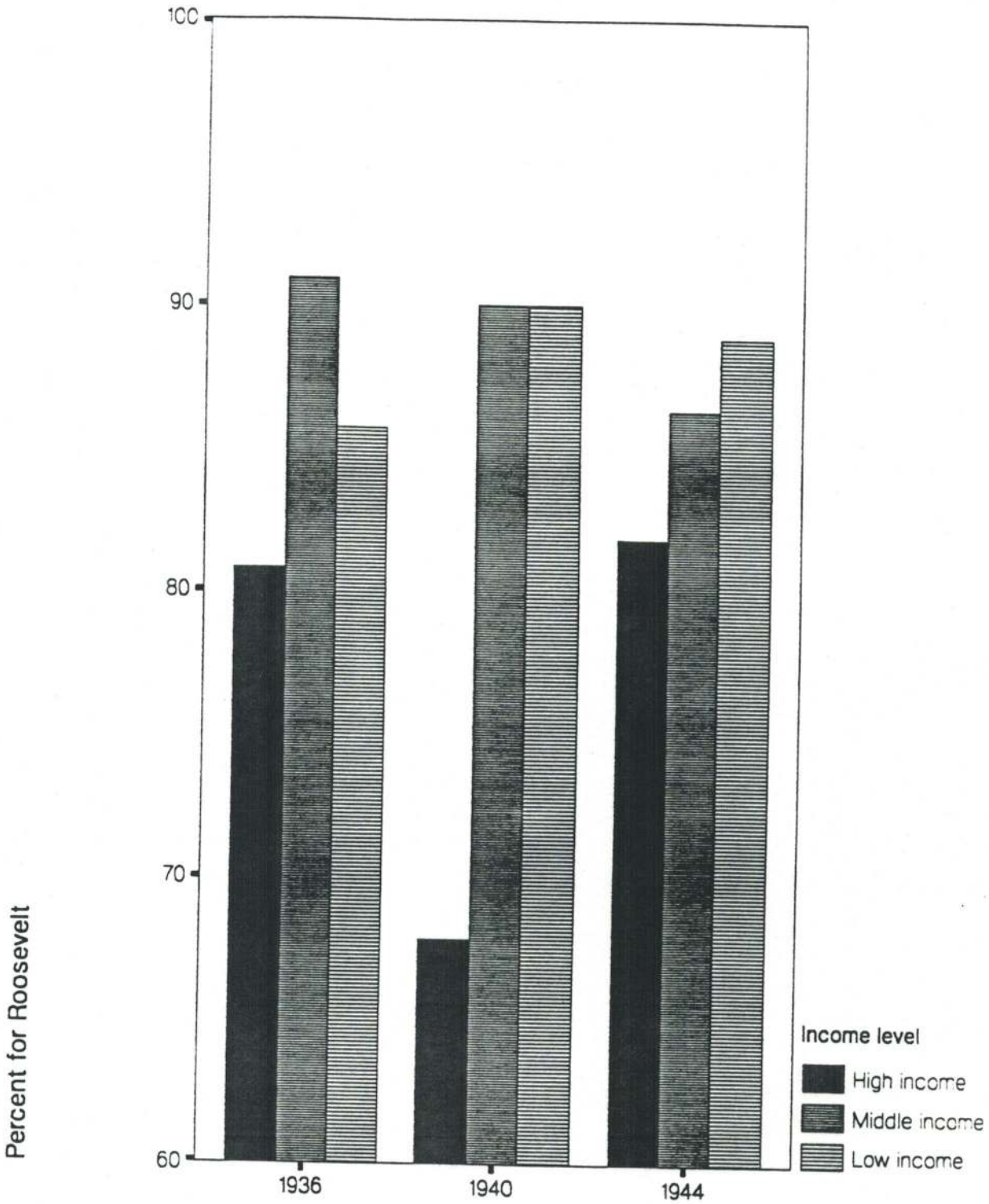
difference of 28.2 points). This meant that the same set of social and demographic forces affected both Catholics and northern Protestants. On the other hand, Jewish voters were unaffected by the class factor, except perhaps in 1940, when a noticeable number of rich Jewish voters switched to Willkie. However, most of them switched back in 1944 (Figure 7).

To sort out which of these forces played the biggest roles in election outcomes during these years, multivariate analysis must be used. This is because factors such as income level, religion, ethnicity, community size and union membership overlap so much that it is otherwise impossible to tell them apart. From our analysis, we learn that at least two of these factors, religious denomination and

Figure 7

Jewish Support for Roosevelt by Income Level, 1936-1944

(Non-Southern Voters Only)

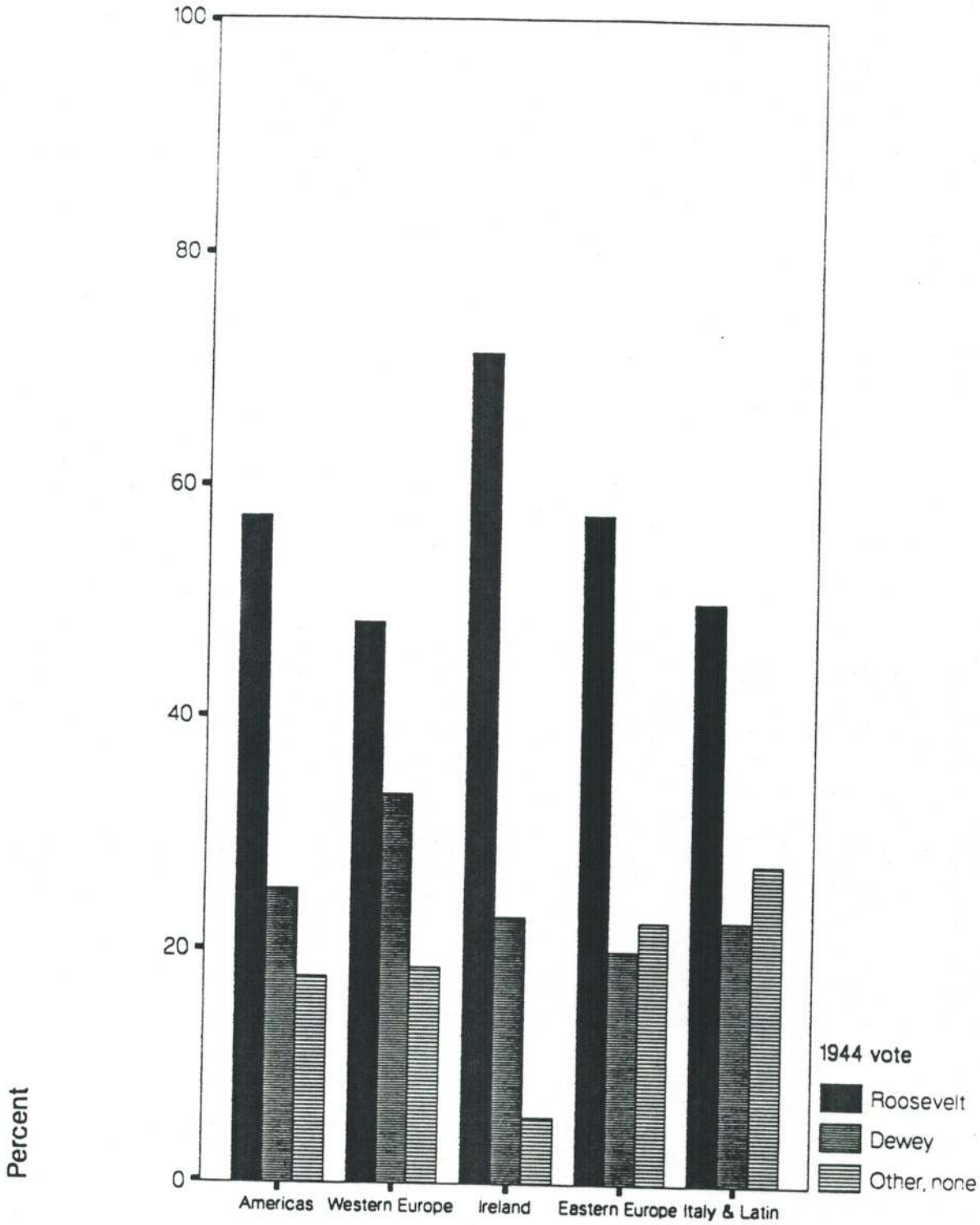


Source: NORC nos. 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

income level, were dominant. Other effects can also be detected, but they weaken considerably once these two factors are controlled for. In 1944, for example, ethnicity seemed almost as important as religion and income level; its eta coefficient (.19), a correlation coefficient that measures a factor's effect on the vote, nearly equalled the coefficient for income level (.22) (Table IX). That is, ethnicity helps explain why the Irish were 44.9 points more Democratic than average; the British, .5 points more Democratic than average; the Scandinavians, -10.8 points less Democratic than average, etc. Controlling for religion and income level, however, weakens the relationship considerably (the eta coefficient drops from .19 to .06). In contrast, the eta coefficients for economic level and religion remain stable (income level drops from .22 to .21, and religion, from .27 to .26). This means, for example, that in 1944, rich Italian Catholics voted like rich German Catholics, rich Polish Catholics, etc., and low-income northern Protestant British voted like low-income northern Protestant Americans, and so forth. The Irish were the major exception; even after controlling for religion and income level, they were still 22 points more Democratic than average. By examining one group in particular, northern Catholics, Figure 8 demonstrates the relative unimportance of ethnicity on the vote within religious denominations.

Figure 8
Catholic Presidential Voting by Ethnic Origin, 1944

(Non-Southerners Only)



Source: NORC nos. 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

TABLE IX

THE 1944 VOTE BY RELIGION, ETHNICITY AND INCOME LEVEL, NON-SOUTH

		Observed deviation above or below average	Eta	Adjusted deviation above or below average	Beta
Overall mean	N	49.8		49.8	
Religion			.27		.26
Protestant	1189	-7.5		-6.8	
Catholic	360	15.8		12.8	
Other, none	27	22.5		20.4	
Jewish	83	32.2		35.0	
Income level			.22		.21
High income	291	-15.4		-15.2	
Middle income	905	-2.3		-2.2	
Low income	463	14.2		13.7	
Ethnicity			.19		.06
Scandinavia	53	-5.4		2.8	
West Europe	143	-5.0		-5.0	
Americas	1158	-3.3		-.4	
Britain	81	0.2		4.8	
Italy & Latin	68	15.7		-2.8	
Ireland	36	22.5		10.6	
East Europe	120	24.8		3.7	

Source: NORC 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

Entries are deviations above or below the overall mean.
A Roosevelt vote=100; a Republican vote=0; and other-novote=50.

Large victories in the cities became increasingly important to Roosevelt to offset decided Republican trends in small towns and in the countryside. Between 1936 and 1944, metropolitan majorities in five states (New York, Illinois, Massachusetts, Maryland and California), consistently put those states in the Democratic column,

along with their 123 electoral votes. A total of 266 electoral votes were needed to win. In three states (Michigan, Missouri and Pennsylvania), urban victories failed only once to swing the state to the Democrats. In Ohio and Wisconsin, by contrast, the metropolitan areas controlled their states only once. When put together, this means that in 1940 Roosevelt won nine states, or 212 electoral votes, because he carried the cities in those states; and in 1944, he won 193 electoral votes because of the cities. Without strong urban support, he might have lost those elections (Table X).

TABLE X

DEMOCRATIC ELECTORAL COLLEGE VOTES WON BY METROPOLITAN PLURALITIES, 1932-1944

	Election Year			
	1932	1936	1940	1944
State				
New York	47	47	47	47
Illinois	29	29	29	28
Pennsylvania			36	35
Michigan	19	19		19
Ohio	26		26	
Maryland	8	8	8	8
Missouri			15	15
Massachusetts	17	17	17	16
Wisconsin			12	
California	22	22	22	25
Total =	168	142	212	193

Source: Eldersveld, Samuel: "The Influence of Metropolitan Elites". The American Politican Science Review, 1949, p. 119

Community size alone does not explain why the cities voted Democratic. The chief reason was that strong Democratic groups like non-Protestant, ethnic minorities (Jews, Poles, Italians, and Irish), blacks and union members were largely located in big cities. For example, 34% of city residents were Catholic, versus just 23% in smaller cities, 13% in towns, and 9% on farms. In addition, 10% of city dwellers were Jewish, whereas almost no Jews lived in smaller communities. The cities were also homes to 72% of the nation's Irish, 70% of Eastern Europeans, and 63% of persons from Italy or Latin counties. Roosevelt wooed these groups into his coalition by channeling jobs, relief and recognition through Democratic city machines and agencies such as the Works Projects Administration, Federal Emergency Relief Administration, Civilian Conservation Corps and National Youth Administration.

Table XI shows the relative unimportance of the community size effect in 1944 after controlling for religion and economic level (the eta coefficient drops from .18 to .09). In contrast, the religious and economic level effects stayed nearly the same, which meant that they affected the vote almost the same way in big cities and in small towns. However, even after controlling for religion and economic level, a residual community size effect still remained. Farmers were still 17 points less Democratic than average, and large city residents, 7 points more than average. This

helps explain, for example, who low-income Protestants in large urban areas voted so heavily for Roosevelt, while their counterparts on farms favored Dewey (Figure 9).

TABLE XI

THE 1944 VOTE BY RELIGION, INCOME LEVEL AND COMMUNITY SIZE, NON-SOUTH

		Observed deviation above or below average	Eta	Adjusted deviation above or below average	Beta
Overall mean	N	49.8		49.8	
Religion			.27		.24
Protestant	1190	-7.6		-6.4	
Catholic	361	15.7		11.8	
Jewish	30	23.5		19.8	
Other, none	84	32.3		33.5	
Income level			.22		.21
High income	292	-15.6		-14.8	
Middle income	907	-2.3		-2.0	
Low income	466	14.2		13.2	
Community size			.18		.09
1,000,000 & larger	630	8.1		3.7	
50,000-1,000,000	371	1.1		1.2	
Small towns	456	-4.8		-2.3	
Farms	208	-16.2		-8.3	

Source: NORC 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

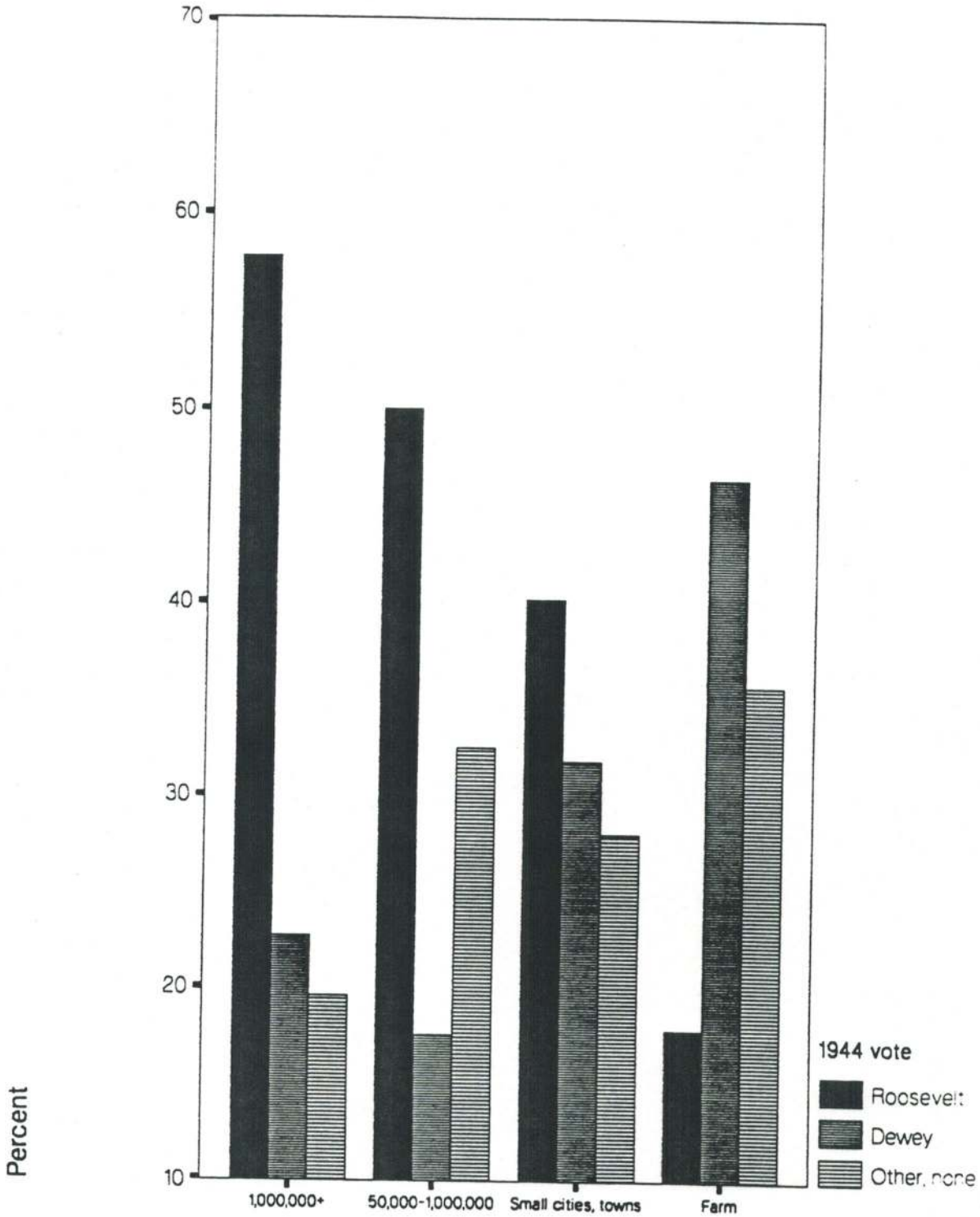
Entries are deviations above or below the overall mean.
A Roosevelt vote=100; a Republican vote=0; and other-novote=50.

The growth of labor unions was a chief byproduct of New Deal legislation. Although unions were extremely weak before 1933, they flourished under Roosevelt, surging in

Figure 9

Low-income Protestant Voting by Community Size, 1944

(Non-Southerners Only)



Source: NORC nos. 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

membership to 10 million on the eve of World War II, and to more than 14 million by the end of the war. In 1937 alone, unions won dramatic victories against large corporations such as General Motors and United States Steel. In return for general encouragement by the Roosevelt administration, and favorable legislation such as Section 7A of the National Industrial Recovery Act and the Wagner Act, union members became some of Roosevelt's staunchest and most loyal supporters. A remarkably high level of union support carried over into the 1940 and 1944 elections. This was especially true of Congress of Industrial Organizations (CIO) members (92% resupported Roosevelt in 1940, and 91% in 1944), but members of the American Federation of Labor (AFL) and other unions resupported him at high levels too.

While labor unions were a key element in the Roosevelt coalition, the effect of union membership on the vote diminishes somewhat after controlling for religion and income level (the eta coefficient drops from .19 to .13). The explanation is that divisions along religious and economic lines existed within unions, just as within society at large. This means that while labor unions were important, America still did not have a homogeneous working class as could be found in Europe. Consequently, unions operated as just another interest group in a pluralistic society, and generally could only be mobilized when issues affecting jobs and salaries were at stake. Even after

controlling for religion and income level, however, C.I.O. members were still 32 points more Democratic than average, and A.F. of L. members (Table XII).

TABLE XII

THE 1944 VOTE BY RELIGION, INCOME LEVEL AND UNION MEMBERSHIP, NON-SOUTH

		Observed deviation above or below average	Eta	Adjusted deviation above or below average	Beta
Overall mean	N	49.8		49.8	
Religion			.28		.26
Protestant	1171	-7.7		-6.8	
Catholic	356	15.8		12.1	
Jewish	83	23.5		20.3	
Other, none	30	32.1		36.6	
Income level			.22		.18
High income	288	-15.4		-12.8	
Middle income	894	-2.2		-2.0	
Low income	458	14.1		11.9	
Union			.19		.13
C.I.O. member	151	22.4		15.8	
A.F. of L. member	176	9.0		7.1	
Other union	68	10.5		4.5	
Non-union member	1245	-4.6		-3.2	

Source: NORC 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

Entries are deviations above or below the overall mean.
A Roosevelt vote=100; a Republican vote=0; and other-novote=50.
Source: NORC nos. 229/230 (October-November, 1944)

Thus, analysis of public opinion polls reveals three major factors which affected voting during the 1930s and 1940s; religious denomination, income level and union

membership. Two other factors which are often considered prominent, ethnicity and community size, were less important after controlling for these other three factors. While this does not negate the importance of urban-rural and ethnic factors on New Deal era voting, it does mean that Americans were more likely to vote along with their own income group or religious denomination, than according to community size or ethnic background. In other words, the cities were critical to Roosevelt not just because they were large, but because they contained such high concentrations of non-Protestants and low income voters.

In some ways, this paper glosses over the importance of issues during the New Deal years. Clearly, Social Security was important in 1936. Unfortunately, most early election polls rarely asked very many questions on the issues of the day. For example, the 1940 Gallup post-election poll, had questions on foreign policy, but none at all on the third-term issue. The reason for this oversight is that most commercial polls were never intended as election studies, not like the ones conducted by the Survey Research Center in the 1950s and after. As a result, my decision to focus on demographic factors was not meant to dismiss the importance of attitudes on the vote, but to deal instead with the data which were available.